

Cover story **RURAL INDIA**

prices may be pinching the pockets of the urban consumers, but it has brought new affluence to farmers who have nearly trebled their income in recent years, along with aspirations. Katkade's new home resembles any middle-class household in urban India and his daughter Priyanka is studying in Mumbai. Says the proud father: "I want her to go to an engineering college."

Thavamurugan from Valliammalpuram near Theni, close to Madurai, is another farmer who benefited from a change of crop. He used to grow tea, coffee, pepper or sugarcane before he switched to grapes. Theni's climate allows grapes to grow all year round and now some 10,000 tonnes of Thomson seedless grapes are produced annually. "Theni is almost the world capital for Thomson grapes. Our farmers are competing in the world market," says Thavamurugan. Though he lives in a small village near Theni, his huge farmhouse boasts of a high-end computer, a treadmill, and a Toyota Innova.

New Innovations Apart from crop changes, innovative farming techniques are boosting productivity, encouraging new entrepreneurship and having a huge social impact. Yalala Srinivas, 32, from Murthad in Telangana, owns a four-acre farm but now sells drip irrigation systems and micro irrigation techniques to nearby farmers. His income has grown; he has bought an Alto and now wants to complete his studies. "Advising

farmers on modern cultivation methods is good for the growth of the local economy and my business," says Srinivas.

The flowering of ambition and enterprise through farming is widespread in Murthad, which for a population of 14,000 boasts of 3,500 motorcycles, 20 cars and 32 tractors that are seldom idle. Most houses have concrete roofs, rare enough in rural Telangana, as well as modern kitchens and cooking gas stoves. A decade ago, that was unthinkable. Local farmers produce nearly 70 per cent of the national requirement of red jowar seeds which are then sold to seed companies. The impact on the local economy is considerable. Twenty-five thousand farmers provide direct employment to another 25,000 families. Moreover, rural youth, sporting cellphones and clad in fake designer wear, are no longer forced to migrate to cities in search of jobs.

Jowar is the real money spinner and another indicator of how rural marketing is changing the rules of the game. In the 1980s, seed companies offered farmers a buy-back guarantee. "What began as an experiment has become a bumper success," says Enugu Gangaram, 45, a red jowar producer. Nearly 50,000 acres produce four lakh quintal of seeds a year. This has led to 35 seed processing plants in the area, adding to the value chain. Palle Ganga Reddy, director, Andhra Pradesh State Seeds Corporation, says that the seed is procured, processed and packed locally, and is also exported to Pakistan and



by PRABHAKAR RAO/www.indianexpress.com



TEEGALA RAMESH REDDY
FARMER, ANDHRA PRADESH

From his back-breaking days in the blazing sun tilling 13 acres of arid land in Murthad, a Telangana village, he has come a long way after he started cultivating red jowar and building a seed bank. Now, he drives around in an Alto and chats with his daughter Ramani on his cellphone. She is a graduate from California State University and works for a US-based IT company.